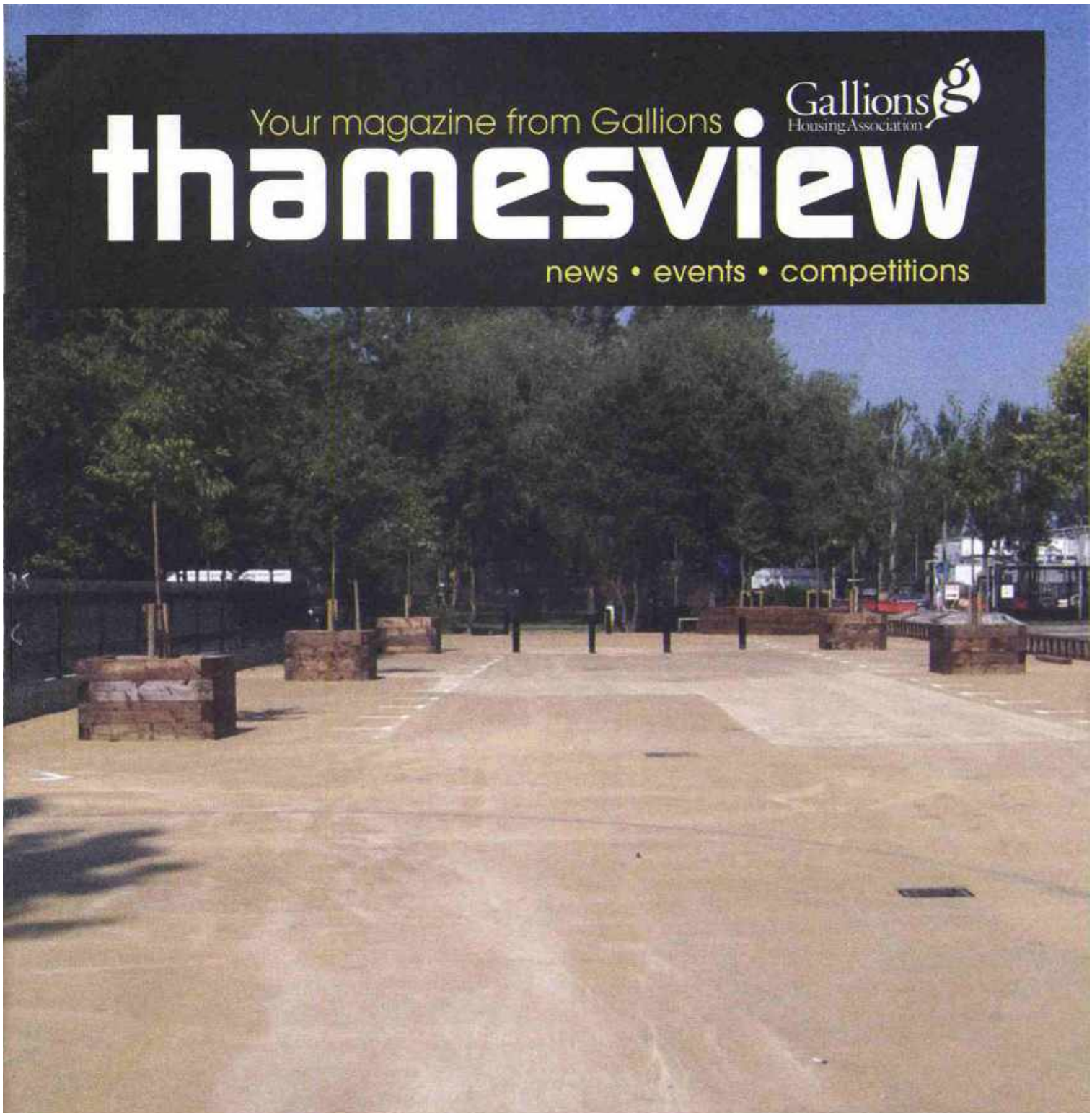
Your magazine from Gallions

Gallions Housing Association

thamesview

news • events • competitions



Alsike Road regeneration project completed 5

Mediation: helping neighbours in dispute 9-11

Thamesmead's hidden jewel 16

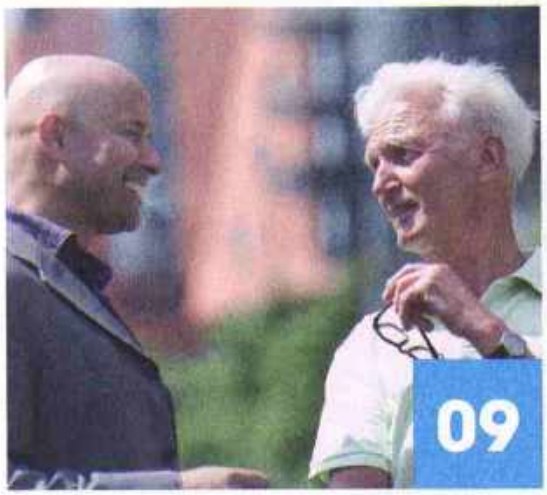
Have your boiler checked 24

December 2013 • www.gallionsha.co.uk

CONTENTS

December 2013 • www.gallionsha.co.uk


05


09


13


18


25

Get in touch

Contact us: 0300 123 1237

Write to us: PO BOX 268, Sidcup, DA15 0FB

Visit us: 15 Joyce Dawson Way, London, SE28 8RA

Open between 9am and 5pm on Monday, Tuesday, Thursday and Friday. On Wednesdays we are open from 9am until 6pm.

Or telephone us:

Customer Contact Team: 0300 123 1237

Repairs Contact Team: 0300 123 1238

Gas appliances servicing and break downs: 020 8300 0300

Text Relay: 18001

05 **Alsike Road**
Regeneration project completed

06 **Feeling the pinch**
Financial advice and guidance

09 **Mediation**
The service that helps neighbours in dispute

13 **Parent and child**
Healthy cookery course

16 **Thamesmead's hidden jewel**
The Link Thamesmead is a year old

18 **TBRRAG fun day**
A great success

20 **Information for leaseholders and freeholders**

24 **Boilers**
Have yours checked regularly

25 **Gallions says thank you to residents**

25 Things to do

27 Wordsearch

RESIDENT ADVICE

This section explains what advice Gallions, our partners and local community groups would like to tell residents. This could include ways you can get involved with your local community or advice on money, housing or DIY activities.

NEIGHBOURS

This section explains what's going on in your neighbourhood – everything from events to what exciting projects your neighbours are up to and ways to get involved.

If you would like to submit an article to this section please email communications@gallionsha.co.uk or call 0208 308 4080

TENANTS VIEW

This section is for residents by residents. Get involved and write an article from your point of view on what's happening in your community. Get your neighbours talking about local issues or things to celebrate!

If you would like to submit an article to this section please email communications@gallionsha.co.uk or call 0208 308 4080

GALLIONS

This section is where you be able to find the latest information on what Gallions is up to; everything from performance to what local offers we have available. You will find out all the latest information from your landlord here.

EVENTS

This section is where you can sit back with a cup of tea or coffee and plan your events and have a go at our crosswords and win some prizes.

WELCOME

Summer is well behind us now and some of you may be thinking about Christmas. Where did the year go? In this issue of Thamesview we will be providing you with the latest news and information from ourselves and our partners.

We have just finished our Alsike Road regeneration project; which has dramatically changed the local landscape. Read all about it on page five. If you are finding it hard to make ends meet, our double-page spread on pages six and seven might be useful.

As well as our regular areas, there is also a handy feature (pages 9-11) on how you could make use of mediation services to help resolve common neighbourly disputes.



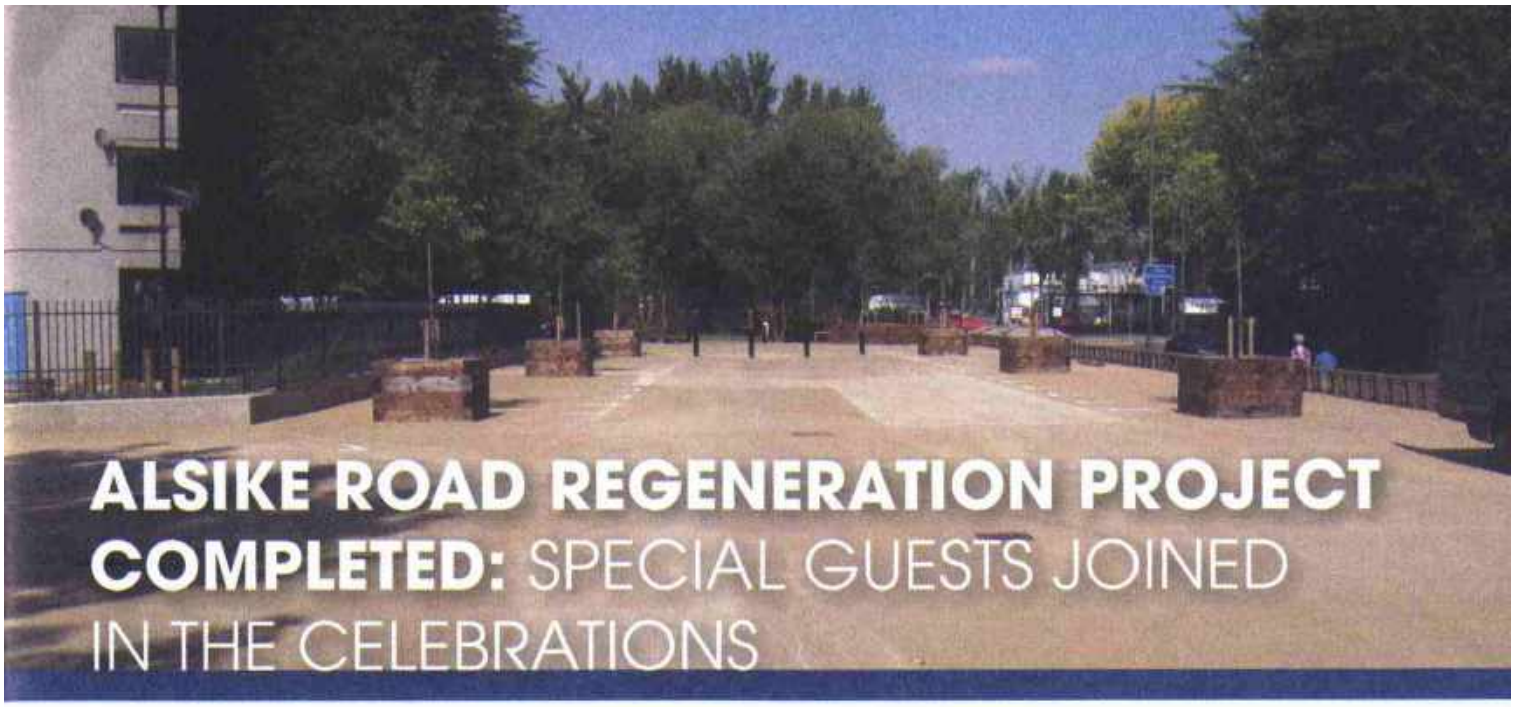
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Gallions Residents Group

Gallions Housing Association



ALSIKE ROAD REGENERATION PROJECT COMPLETED: SPECIAL GUESTS JOINED IN THE CELEBRATIONS

REPRESENTATIVES FROM MULALLEY, LONDON BOROUGH OF BEXLEY AND TRUST THAMESMEAD GOT TOGETHER WITH OURSELVES IN OCTOBER TO CELEBRATE COMPLETION OF THE ALSIKE ROAD REGENERATION PROJECT.

We were also joined by children from Willow Bank Primary School – who were given a lively presentation on health and safety around construction sites and the possible jobs they could get into after leaving school.

The project, located just off Yarnton Way, South Thamesmead, saw huge changes over the past 18 months, including:

- Demolition of walkways and garages, which will make the area more visually attractive whilst also improving the local environment.
- Three new community gardens and a dog walking area.
- Tearing down unnecessary concrete to improve the public realm and reduce dead ends.
- More open areas with improved landscapes; promoting natural site-wide surveillance.

The project represented a significant step in our £50m Transforming Towers programme, which will include removing the Yarnton Way wall, which has divided communities for 45 years, and completely upgrading the fabric of 19 towers in South Thamesmead.

Dan Hill, Head of Regeneration for Gallions, couldn't hide his delight as he spoke to the small crowd at the event. He said: "I'm really pleased that we have had the opportunity to share this success today with the local community. This project has really improved anti-social behaviour in this area, by knocking down the garages and walls, and creating community gardens for neighbours to meet one another."

Cllr Linda Bailey, Bexley's Cabinet Member for Economic Development and Regeneration, was very pleased with the progress. She said: "It's great news that the regeneration of Thamesmead is starting to take shape and the completion of the Alsike Road project proves major progress is being made."

To find out more please contact:
David Adesoye
e: dadesoye@gallionsha.co.uk
t: 020 8308 4114

FEELING THE PINCH?

HELP IS AT HAND WITH *FAIR FINANCE, CREDIT UNION, THAMESMEAD FURNITURE RECYCLE* AND *THAMESMEAD FOODBANK* ALL OPERATING IN THAMESMEAD. BETWEEN THEM, THEY HAVE HELPED MANY THAMESMEAD RESIDENTS, FROM ADVICE AND GUIDANCE TO SUPPLYING GOODS AND LOANS.



The Fair Finance Team

Fair Finance's Fair Money Advice Debt Advisor provides free confidential and impartial advice to Thamesmead residents out of Trust Thamesmead's office (based in Thamesmead Town Centre). So if you're experiencing financial difficulties or have any concerns about debt, rent or mortgage arrears then this could be the service for you.

Fair Personal Loans have supplied 151 affordable loans to Thamesmead residents since 2012; many of whom were unemployed, on benefits or facing a county court judgement. Unlike banks, their granting of a personal loan is based on each individual's needs and not solely on a credit rating or a computer's say so.

Trust Thamesmead works closely with Greenwich and Bexley Credit Union who can offer residents a loan with very good interest rates. So between them, Fair Finance and the Credit Union give residents an alternative to those hefty pay day loan companies and door-step lenders who charge interest rates way beyond anyone's means.

If you would like to make an appointment with Fair Finance, call Trust Thamesmead's office on 020 8320 4470 or email info@fairmoneyadvice.co.uk

Contact Greenwich and Bexley Credit Union on 020 8855 4344 or visit www.greenwichcreditunion.co.uk

THAMESMEAD FOODBANK

ALSO OPERATING OUT OF THAMESMEAD IS THAMESMEAD FOODBANK, WHICH IS ON HAND TO HELP THOSE WHO, FOR ONE REASON OR ANOTHER, ARE UNABLE TO MEET THOSE WEEKLY SHOPPING BILLS.

It doesn't matter why you would approach them – it could be down to a personal crisis, sudden job loss, illness, separation or homelessness. Foodbanks have fed 346,992 people nationwide in the last 12 months.

No one in Thamesmead needs to go hungry. To get in touch call 020 8311 3976 or 07915 999 306.



THAMESMEAD FURNITURE RECYCLE

ANOTHER FANTASTIC RESOURCE IN THAMESMEAD IS THAMESMEAD FURNITURE RECYCLE BASED AT THE UNDERCROFT IN KALE ROAD, DA18 4BJ (OPPOSITE ST JOHN FISHER PRIMARY SCHOOL).

Open 9:00am -1:00pm, Monday-Friday, residents can buy good quality clean, second-hand furniture and other household items at very affordable prices.

For further information
t: 020 8312 9191 or e: thamesmead-furniture-recycle@live.co.uk

PLEASE CONTACT THE COMPANIES MENTIONED INDIVIDUALLY OR POP IN AND FIND OUT MORE AT YOUR LOCAL TRUSTY COMMUNITY DEVELOPMENT AGENCY, TRUST THAMESMEAD, 19A JOYCE DAWSON WAY, THAMESMEAD TOWN CENTRE, SE28 8RA
T: 020 8320 4470.

ALTERNATIVELY, IF YOU ARE IN THE FORTUNATE POSITION OF BEING ABLE TO HELP OTHERS (TIME OR GOODS), THEY WOULD ALSO LIKE TO HEAR FROM YOU!

FREE TRAINING

IF YOU LIVE IN THAMESMEAD, ARE AGED 16+, UNEMPLOYED AND ARE LOOKING FOR TRAINING, THEN YOU'VE COME TO THE RIGHT PLACE! TRUST THAMESMEAD'S TRAINING AND JOB SEARCH DEPARTMENT, BUILDING FUTURES, IS HERE TO HELP.



The Building Futures Team

Offering many free courses including Universal Credit Workshop, Food Safety, Childcare, First Aid, Security, Warehouse/ Forklift and Construction Skills Certification Scheme (CSCS); there's something for everyone, so why not register today?

Telephone 020 8320 4470 or pop in to make an appointment and find out more at Trust Thamesmead, 19a Joyce Dawson Way, Thamesmead Town Centre, SE28 8RA.

FREE SEWING AND TEXTILES TRAINING COURSE FOR GALLIONS RESIDENTS

HAVE YOU ALWAYS WANTED TO LEARN HOW TO SEW, MAKE YOUR OWN CLOTHES, EVEN START YOUR OWN BUSINESS?

Then this could be the course for you; it includes:

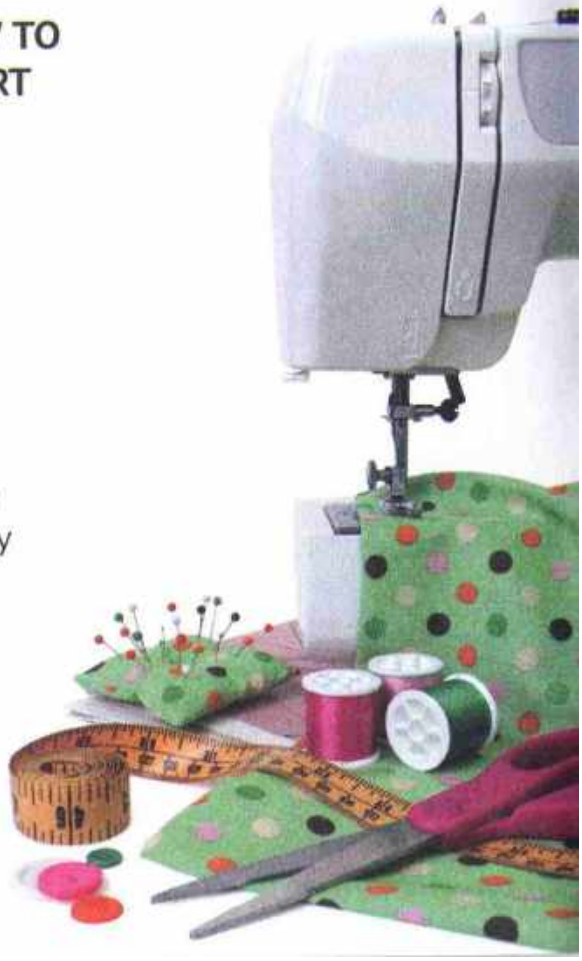
- using the sewing machine,
- pattern cutting,
- textile design, and
- embroidering

All levels of ability welcome

The course starts January 2014, 11am – 1pm at the ARC Training Centre, 34-36 Grovebury Road, Abbey Wood, London, SE2 9BB. Attendance is only two hours a week for 13 weeks.

Only 10 spaces available

To book your place, please contact Ameen Hussain at the ARC Training Centre on 020 8310 7777





MEDIATION: THE SERVICE THAT HELPS NEIGHBOURS IN DISPUTE

Did you know that some common neighbourly disputes; sometimes involving noise, smells or boisterous children; can be sorted out with the help of mediation? So if you have a problem with your neighbour and both want it resolved before it gets too far; why not try mediation?

To make it easier for you to get the help you need, we have teamed up with Bromley Community Mediation Service to bring this facility to you. If you would like to take it up, please contact your Neighbourhood Services Officer on 0300 123 1237.

SOME MORE DETAILS ABOUT MEDIATION

WHAT IS MEDIATION?

Mediation is a method of resolving misunderstandings, disputes and conflicts by a process of discussion and negotiation between the parties involved. The process is managed by a Mediator who is independent and neutral. The Mediator helps the parties to identify and explore the issues affecting them and to find practical solutions that will resolve the problems they are experiencing. ➜

WHAT DOES THE MEDIATOR DO?

The Mediator acts as an intermediary who assists the parties to have a constructive discussion and to negotiate, even though they might otherwise feel unable to talk to each other. The Mediator helps each party to identify and understand both sides of the argument and to discover all of the issues that affect the situation.

The Mediator then helps the parties to find common ground, and points on which they can agree to differ, and to reach an agreement on how to resolve the problems affecting them.

WHERE AND HOW DOES IT HAPPEN?

Mediators normally work in pairs. They meet each party separately at home for one or more private and confidential meetings in order to learn about what is happening directly from the people affected and to discuss what is concerning them.

Subsequently, when the parties are ready and the Mediator feels that it is possible to negotiate an effective agreement, the Lead Mediator organises a joint meeting at a neutral venue. The purpose of the joint meeting is to enable the parties to arrive at an agreement, which the Mediators then set out in writing for the parties to sign.

IS IT CONFIDENTIAL?

Yes. The Mediators observe a code of confidentiality and will not reveal anything that is said by one party to the other party without permission.

The effectiveness of mediation depends on mediator trust, and the knowledge that either party can reveal information or a controversial point of view to the Mediators in the knowledge that it will remain confidential.

HOW LONG DOES IT TAKE?

This depends partly on the availability of the parties and their cooperation in agreeing and adhering to meeting arrangements. Once the process begins, the aim is to conclude the mediation process within a period of two to three weeks.

WHAT IS THE END RESULT?

That is for the parties to decide. The Mediator's role is to help the parties to resolve their dispute and this normally means preparing a signed written agreement that sets out the understandings reached and a new code of conduct for the future.

Mediators are skilled at helping people to achieve this objective, and where parties cooperate with the process the success rate is high.

SUPPOSE THE OTHER PARTY DOES NOT WANT TO GET INVOLVED IN MEDIATION?

Mediation is voluntary. Therefore, the parties must first confirm that they are willing to participate. Mediators are happy to explain and to help an initially reluctant party to understand the process and the benefits to be gained.

However, ultimately the choice is theirs. Once the process is underway, the parties need to work constructively with the Mediation Team. The Mediators will not take sides, but will guide the process to ensure that each party expresses and communicates their point of view.

The Mediators may also make suggestions on how to reach an agreement that resolves the issues at stake.

AT WHAT STAGE SHOULD YOU BE THINKING ABOUT MEDIATION?

Cases are often more difficult if the differences between the parties have been allowed to become protracted and entrenched, so with this in mind, it is useful to consider mediation as a first, rather than a last resort.

If you are in dispute with your neighbour and would like to consider mediation as a way to resolve the matter, then contact your Neighbourhood Services Officer on 0300 123 1237.

MEDIATION IS FREE TO GALLIONS RESIDENTS AND IS A PROVEN AND EFFECTIVE WAY TO RESOLVE DISPUTES.

GALLIONS AND GREENWICH COUNCIL JOIN FORCES TO CRACK DOWN ON SUB LETTING

WE ARE CONTINUING TO HAVE GREAT SUCCESS CRACKING DOWN ON UNLAWFUL SUB LETTING AND WOULD LIKE TO THANK ALL RESIDENTS THAT HAVE SUPPLIED VALUABLE INFORMATION (WHICH WE DEAL WITH CONFIDENTIALLY) WHICH WAS SO HELPFUL TO US.

Royal Borough of Greenwich has received additional government funding to further tackle tenancy fraud. We are pleased to announce that we are working in partnership with them in this exercise and will be sharing residents data to make it easier to spot any fraudsters; where we come across them, they will be tackled and their properties given back to those that are most in need.

Please continue to report any suspicions via our website or call centre on 0300 123 1237.

BLOOMING LOVELY!





IT SEEMS LIKE SUCH A LONG TIME AGO NOW BUT CAST YOUR MINDS BACK TO THOSE GLORIOUS SUNNY JULY DAYS WHEN, INDEED, THAMESMEAD WAS BLOOMING.

Back then we ran our annual 'Thamesmead in Bloom' competition with help from The Friends of Thamesmead Parks group. The competition is our way of finding and rewarding those dedicated gardeners that put so much effort into making the area look fantastic.

We had seventeen entries in four categories: best front or back garden, balcony, communal area and best school garden. The lucky winners – all receiving £100 in B&Q vouchers (except the winner of the special commendation award, who received £50 in B&Q vouchers) – were:

- **Mr Walsh** of **Ormesby Close** for the best garden
- **Mr Hadwin** of **Shire Court** for the best balcony
- **Ms Nash** and **Mr Stoker** of **Bentham Road** for best communal area
- **Business Academy Bexley** (Primary School Garden) for best school garden

There was also a special commendation award which was given to Mr Richardson of Aspen Green. The judges loved the tropical look of the garden: it was very unusual for the area.

Well done to all that took part and better luck next year if you didn't win.

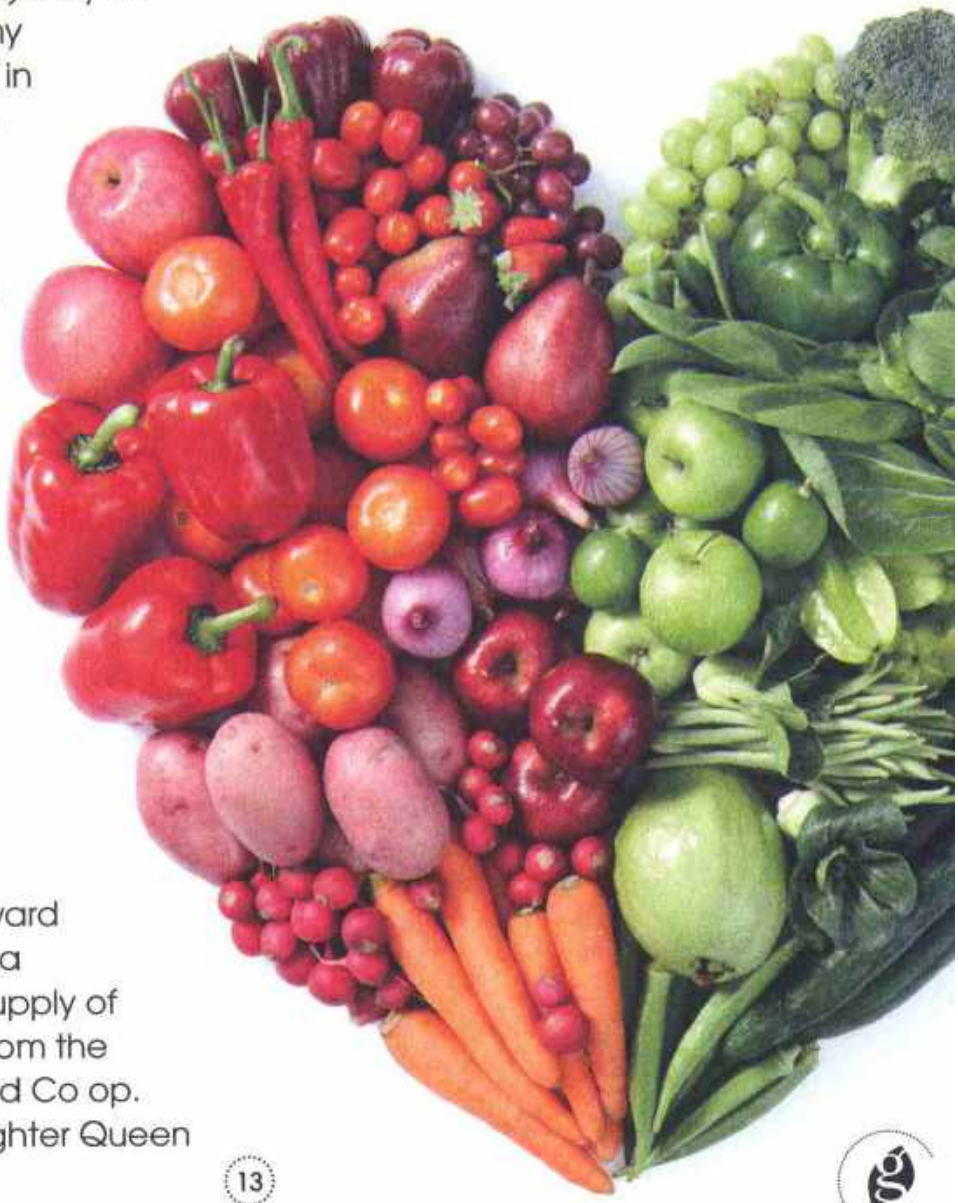
PARENT AND CHILD
HEALTHY COOKERY COURSE

DURING THE SUMMER BREAK, GALLIONS AND GREENWICH COMMUNITY DEVELOPMENT AGENCY (GCDA) LAID ON A FUN FILLED COOKERY COURSE AIMED AT PARENTS AND CHILDREN WITH THE KEY FOCUS ON HEALTHY EATING AND BONDING.

Bexley Business Academy's kitchen was the venue where our budding young cooks and their parents got stuck in. Over two weeks (five sessions) they all got to grips with what healthy eating was all about: which, in a nutshell, means eating less sugar, salt and saturated fat; and more fresh fruit, vegetables, fibre as well as good quality carbohydrates and protein.

They also got the opportunity to prepare a meal on the final day for a very special guest: Mayor of Greenwich, Councillor Angela Cornforth, who wasted no time in sampling the delights on offer and presenting gift vouchers to the children for taking part.

She was also on hand to award one lucky parent and child a subscription for a month's supply of fresh fruit and vegetables from the Greenwich Community Food Co op. Shola Fashina and her daughter Queen were awarded the prize for consistent attendance and for the enthusiasm they both showed. Shola was also given the opportunity to attend the Open College Network course in Healthy Eating & Running a Cookery Club. This will enable her to run her own cookery club for Thamesmead residents in the very near future. ➜



This is what some of the parents and children said about the course...

"It was really interesting. I enjoyed learning about the amount of sugar, fat and salt in different foods"
Queen, age 10

"I really appreciate what Gallions and the others have done. They have given me the knowledge to change my lifestyle. I now want to encourage others to do the same".
Shola (parent)

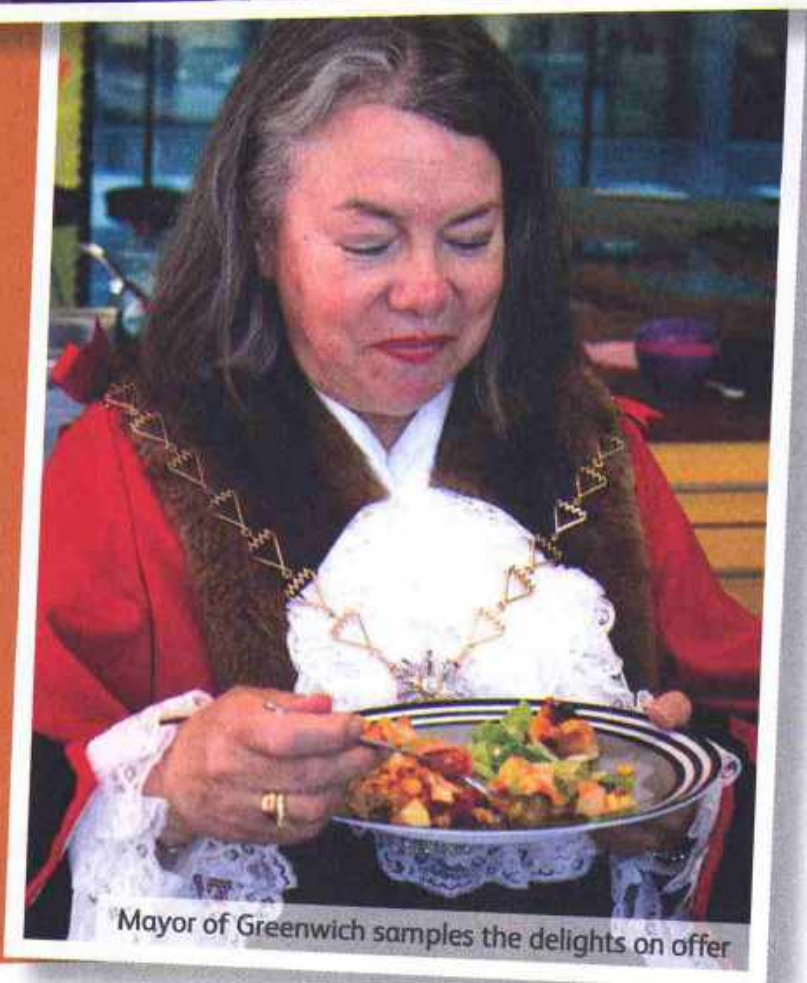
"I came along because I wanted to learn about healthy eating. I also want to be a chef in the future so this was good experience".
Francesco, age 15

Debbie, who attended with her daughter Madison, summed it all up, she said, simply: **"Well worth it...great experience".**

Who knows, maybe one day we will all be eating in Francesco's restaurant but remember where you saw the name first.



Mayor of Greenwich (left) presents Queen (centre) and Shola with their certificate



Mayor of Greenwich samples the delights on offer

LOOK AFTER YOUR HEALTH; JOIN A HEALTHY COOKERY CLUB

Greenwich Council and Greenwich Co-Operative Development Agency are running various free healthy cookery clubs throughout the borough for any resident wanting to learn more about healthy eating. The sessions will last for two and a half hours per week throughout the year (except Christmas and Easter).

For more information call, Greenwich Council on 0800 587 5833.

HIDDEN GEM FOR THE OVER 55'S IN THAMESMEAD

TUCKED AWAY BEHIND CORALLINE WALK (THAMESMEAD) IS A HIDDEN GEM KNOWN AS THE *POP-IN-PARLOUR*.

It's a place where Thamesmead's older residents can simply pop-in for a cup of tea, a natter and so much more - it's also a great place for making new friends. Thamesview caught up with the man responsible for running the parlour and a few regulars to find out what really makes the place such a hit.


John Thompson

John Thompson – or 'Johnny' as his friends affectionately refer to him – has been running the Pop-in-Parlour for 19 years. Currently he is the Chairman and has been for the past 9 years. "I love it here" explained Johnny "I enjoy helping people and the Pop-in-Parlour gives older people in Thamesmead a place to come and meet and enjoy each other's company."

The Pop-in-Parlour is open four days a week and serves anyone over the age of 55 living in Thamesmead. "We have lovely lunches and activities to serve older people and we put on two group holidays per year". Johnny explained that they have different activities Tuesday-Friday. "We have Thai chi on Wednesdays and bingo on Fridays. Those seem to be the most popular days."

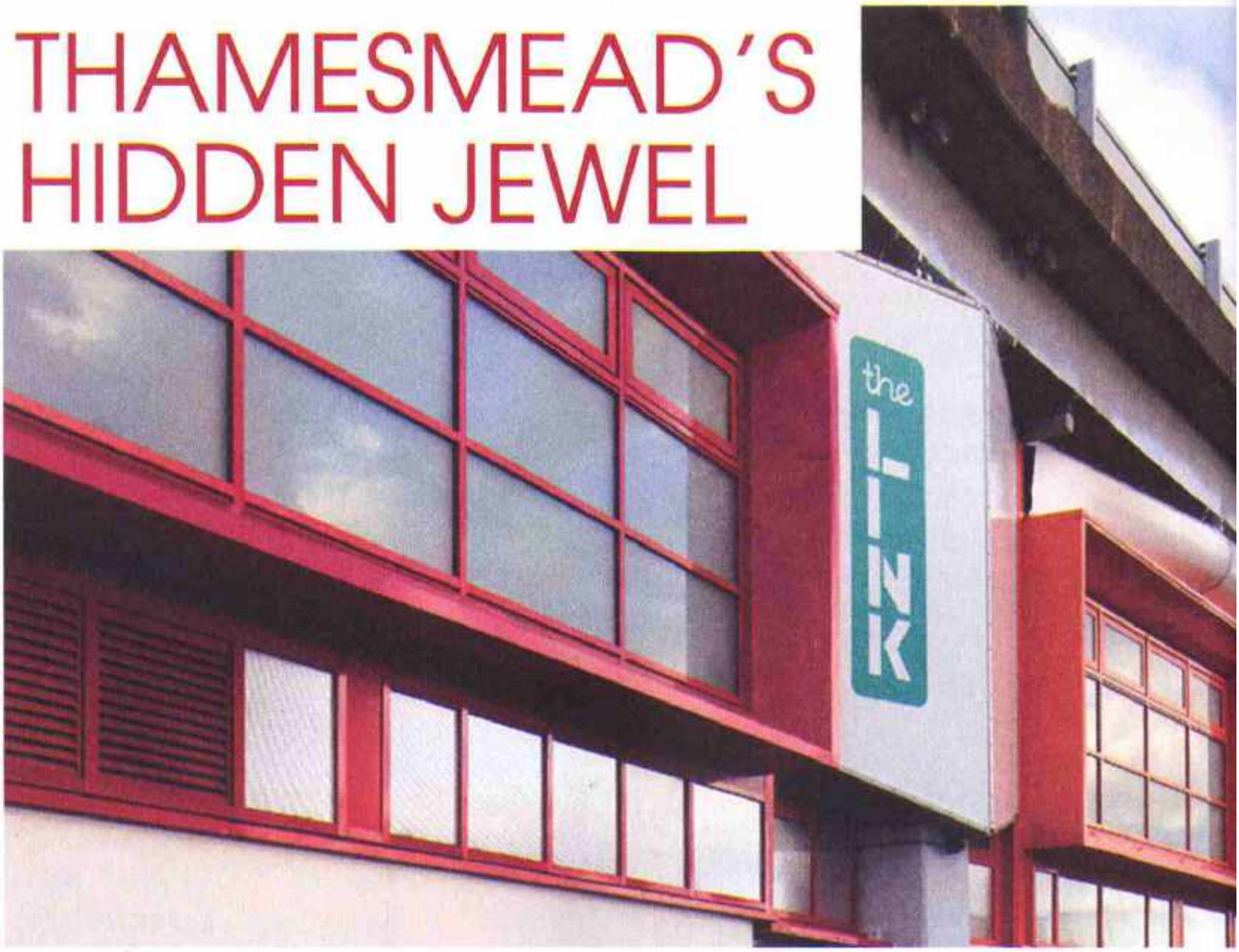
One of the Pop-in-Parlour's regular guests, Iris Williams, enjoys coming and meeting new people and socialising with old friends. "I have been coming for the last 5 years, I like the social aspect. I think I was a bit nervous at first because I didn't know anyone, but everyone was very friendly and I made friends quickly."

One of the residents who has been around for a lot longer, John Boice, agrees. "It's a great place to meet people and I enjoy meeting newcomers." He explained that he has been retired for 23 years and has been coming to the Pop-in-Parlour for over 20 years. "I try to come most days – I have no favourite day as there is always something interesting going on. I always have a good time when I'm here."

The Pop-in-Parlour is open 4 days a week. To get in touch call Johnny on 020 8310 7437 or pop down for a visit: Evenlode House, London SE2 9TP


Regulars enjoying a game of bowls

THAMESMEAD'S HIDDEN JEWEL



HAVE YOU DISCOVERED WHAT'S BASED UNDER THE ROAD IN THE SKY ALONG HARROW MANOR WAY?

Thamesmead's newest youth and community centre, The Link Thamesmead, recently celebrated its first birthday. Based in nine once-disused arches, the building has to be seen to be believed and what's on offer inside is just as brilliant! Home to Thamesmead Youth Voice, Archway Project, Bexley Youth Service, Theatre Street Performing Arts, Thamesmead Gym, Pathway, Pixelform Studios and many more, The Link offers something for everyone from activities, opportunities and spaces for hire.

Misfits used their facilities between filming earlier this year, with Natasha O'Keeffe (Abby) and Karla Crome (Jess) returning during the October half-term to take part in a Q&A session, where they spoke about what it was like to work on the award winning hit TV programme and Ashley from Britain's Got Talent's 2010 runners-up, Twist & Pulse leading a streetomedy class.

October half-term saw lots of other activities taking place including the first quarterly 'community voice' meeting which was opened to everyone who had an interest in South Thamesmead and the surrounding areas - Erith & Thamesmead MP Teresa Pearce attended.

From accredited and non-accredited courses, volunteering opportunities, indoor climbing, motor mechanics, various dance



classes (jazz, tap, ballet, street, Zumba and more!), acting and singing lessons, high and low ropes courses, cookery, photography and filming, as well as recording studio sessions, gym sessions and drop-in sessions (amongst other things) there really is something for everyone...
and that's not all! Charlton Athletic Community Trust will be joining them soon too.

MAKE A CONNECTION
The Link Thamesmead, Belvedere Road, off Harrow Manor Way, Thamesmead, SE2 9BS
t: 020 8320 4499
e: contact@thelinkthamesmead.co.uk
www.thelinkthamesmead.co.uk



GET FIT FOR LIFE AT THE THAMESMEAD GYM

There's plenty on offer at Thamesmead Gym to help you stay fit and healthy, be it pumping weights or receiving one-to-one training and nutrition advice. At just £15 annual membership fee and £3 per session or £35 per month, it's good value too.

Opening times

Monday-Friday	9:00am-9:00pm
Saturdays	10:00am-2:00pm
Sundays	10:00am-1:00pm

Where: The Link Thamesmead
Get in touch: Tel 07914 320554

GET INVOLVED: JOIN THE TEAM GALLIONS INTEREST GROUP

Could you spare one evening every two months to attend a meeting where you get to find out what we are doing to tackle issues such as rubbish dumping, tree pruning, broken paving slabs and much more? Then why not join the Team Gallions Interest Group. Meetings are usually held in Thamesmead.

To find out more contact Steve Pyke, Green Spaces Manager, at Gallions.
e: spyke@gallionsha.co.uk
t: 020 8320 3406

TBRRAG* FUN DAY; A GREAT SUCCESS



By Cherry Kent, Chair of TBRRAG

OUR FUN DAY ON SATURDAY 21ST SEPTEMBER WAS A GREAT SUCCESS.

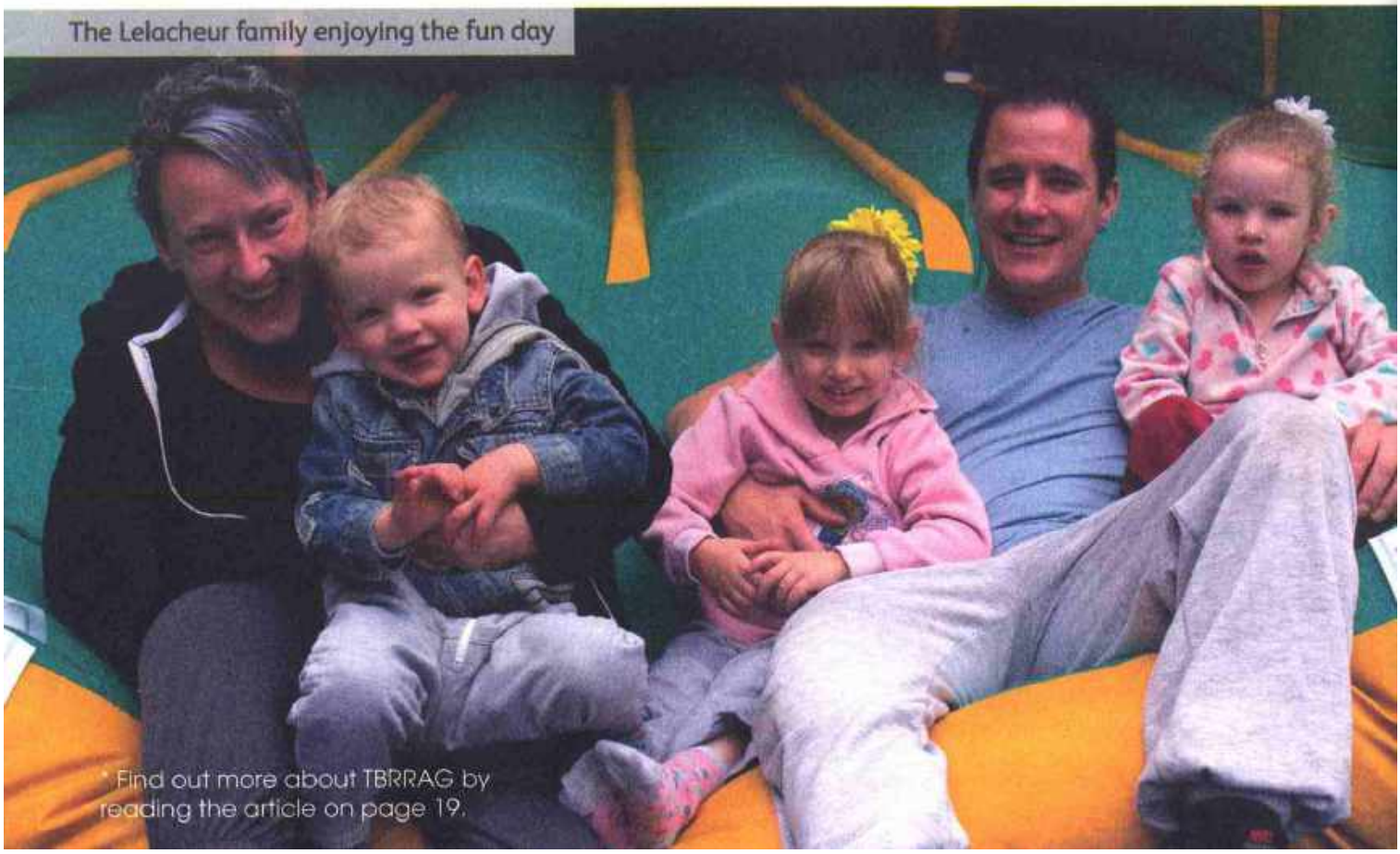
There were about 100 attendees: with 202 vouchers sold for back massages and ice creams, everyone thought it was very good value – we only charged 25p for an ice cream. The weather even played along. All week I had been looking at the rain clouds and crossing my fingers that they would clear up for Saturday and I was very pleased that they did.

There were quite a few groups and special guests that turned up on the day: they all got a lot out of the event. The face painter had a constant queue and proved very popular as did the fire engine, the Feelgood Co-operative, Family Learning and the Dogs Trust.

My thanks in particular go to Linda Delieu from Trust Thamesmead and Helen Chambers from Gallions who helped with the funding and the organisation.

Also, the members of TBRRAG (Chris Ash, Sandra Wright, Violet Wise, Dennis Wilson and Philip Clarke), Thamesmead Gym and the LINK Thamesmead. There were

The Lelacheur family enjoying the fun day



* Find out more about TBRRAG by reading the article on page 19.





a lot of other helpers too, whose names I never discovered; my thanks go to them as well.

I was very pleased to see Councillor Sandra Bauer who came and gave us her support.

Everyone who came enjoyed our fun day and we certainly had a great time. **Same again next year? We'll have to wait and see.**



MORE ABOUT TBRRAG

TBRRAG - Tavy Bridge Regeneration Residents Action Group - is a group of local residents who have regular meetings with Gallions to discuss the regeneration of Southmere Village (previously known as Tavy Bridge) and bring residents issues and problems to their attention.

Some of the many things they have influenced include changing the signage in the area and improving the pedestrian pathways during the demolition. The group will be holding an Annual General Meeting in January and are always keen to hear from local residents who would like to join them.

For more information please contact:
e: TBRRAG@hotmail.co.uk
t: 07930 314 525

INFORMATION FOR LEASEHOLDERS AND FREEHOLDERS

This section is dedicated to information relating specifically to Homeowners

DO YOU NEED A FIRE DOOR IN YOUR PROPERTY?

DID YOU KNOW THAT IF YOU ARE A FLAT OWNER AND YOUR ENTRANCE DOOR OPENS ONTO A COMMUNAL AREA THEN YOUR FRONT DOOR HAS TO BE A 'FIRE DOOR'?

As the landlord or managing agent of the building where your flat is situated we are responsible for the common parts. However under the terms of your lease, you own and are therefore responsible for the flat entrance door and frame.

As part of our duties in carrying out the fire risk assessment and taking the necessary steps to comply with the fire standards we will need you to change your front door to one that meets the 'fire door' standards - if it doesn't already.

Briefly, this means, when shut, the door must be able to keep the flames out of a room for a minimum of 30 minutes. It must also be able to prevent smoke from seeping into the property for about the same length of time. So the seals around the door and frame must meet certain criteria.

It is important that you get the right professional advice when fitting fire doors; but if are doing a spot of DIY you must make sure that the door you select conforms to FD30s standard (in accordance with BS476: Part 22 1987 or BS EN 1634-1 2000) and has a smoke leakage integrity classification of 'Sa'. Now this all sounds very technical but don't worry; help is at hand. If you would like further information on changing your door (or you have already changed your door and want to check that it meets the standards) call Asset Management on 0300 123 1237 and request the leaflet 'How to specify a fire door'.



METAL SECURITY GRILLS:
THEY MAY KEEP INTRUDERS OUT BUT THEY COULD TRAP YOU INSIDE

We know that some leaseholders (and tenants) have fitted metal security grills to doors and windows. This is extremely dangerous as it could prevent you from escaping or the fire brigade entering your property should a fire break out. As part of our duties in carrying out the fire risk assessment and taking the necessary steps to comply with the fire standards, we strongly recommend that you remove any such grills for your own safety.

IN BRIEF: SINKING FUNDS EXPLAINED

What is a sinking fund?
Sinking funds (referred to as a reserve fund in your lease) are ways for landlords to spread the cost of major repairs so that leaseholders do not face sudden large bills. We can only collect a sinking fund if the terms of the lease allow us to.

How it is worked out
We calculate the contribution you are asked to pay by estimating the lifespan of all of the key parts of the building (e.g. lift, roof etc.) and then working out how much it would cost to replace them. In most cases we collect your contribution in line with the terms of your lease.

Advantages of a sinking fund
One of the advantages of selling a property with an existing sinking fund is that the value in the fund will pass to the purchaser. This is likely to mean that the property is not devalued by repairs and replacements which are just around the corner as the fund will take much, if not all, of the cost.

This means where there are two similar properties; one that has a sinking fund and one that doesn't, the one with the fund will be a more attractive property to buy than the one without a fund.

We let you know how the fund is managed
We account to leaseholders for the sinking fund on a yearly basis and will show the contributions demanded during the year, any expenditure in respect of major works for that year and the interest earned on the fund during the year.

GALLIONS AND PEABODY LATEST

We told you previously about our plan to become a subsidiary of Peabody. We are still awaiting formal approval from our regulator - The Homes and Communities Agency - and will let you know once this has been received.

How will Gallions joining Peabody affect you?
You shouldn't notice any immediate difference as a result of the new arrangements. You will continue to receive the same great service from us without changes to your rights as tenants or leaseholders.

Overall we believe that this is good news for you and Thamesmead. Gallions had big plans for making improvements to your homes and regenerating the area but in reality, this would have taken a long time to achieve. With the backing of Peabody, those changes could take place much sooner.

Over the next ten years, Gallions and Peabody intend making massive investments in Thamesmead. This is in addition to some of the great works that are ongoing at the moment. For example, we are regenerating Southmere Village (the area formerly known as Tavy Bridge).

At the end of the project, 296 homes (234 affordable), a new library, four local shops and a major new public square will be available. We are also knocking down some of the high walkways and bridges in South Thamesmead to make the area more accessible and open.

The planned investment will only add to what we are already doing and breathe life into an area that has always had great potential.



HAVING YOUR BOILER REGULARLY CHECKED IS IMPORTANT!



BY LAW WE MUST MAKE SURE THAT THE GAS APPLIANCES WITHIN OUR TENANTED PROPERTIES ARE PROPERLY CHECKED EVERY 12 MONTHS.

If you are a tenant you will receive a letter from our contractor P & R to let you know the date they will service your boiler. This appointment must be kept. If your boiler has not been serviced in 12 months and you have not received a letter please contact our customer services team on 0300 123 1237 and let them know.

Please remember to double check your appointment to ensure you will be available on the day of your servicing appointment. Wasted calls for both servicing and repairs carried out by the contractor are approximately 250 per month.

This means that the contractor is then not able to attend urgent calls as his time is being wasted unnecessarily. Tenants who are found to be wasting the time of the contractor will possibly be recharged.

It is extremely important to have your boiler serviced once a year. If your boiler is not working correctly, it could lead to potential Carbon Monoxide (CO) poisoning that could cause serious harm, or even death.

Approximately 15 deaths per year are caused through gas appliances which have not been checked or serviced.

There are signs that you can look out for that indicate there may be a problem with your boiler:

- Yellow or orange rather than blue flames (except fuel effect fires or flueless appliances which display this colour flame)
- Soot or yellow/brown staining around or on appliances Pilot lights that frequently blow out.

Early symptoms of carbon monoxide (CO) poisoning can mimic many common ailments and may easily be confused with food poisoning, viral infections, flu or simple tiredness.

Symptoms to look out for include:

- **headaches or dizziness**
- **breathlessness**
- **nausea**
- **loss of consciousness**
- **tiredness**
- **pains in the chest or stomach**
- **erratic behaviour**
- **visual problems**

If you or your family experience any of the above symptoms and believe you may have been exposed to carbon monoxide, you should seek urgent medical advice from either your GP or an A&E department.

GALLIONS SAYS THANK YOU TO RESIDENTS


Mandy Doe

Our Managing Director, Mandy Doe, recently hosted a small event at Sporting Club Thamesmead to say thank you to residents for their involvement in helping to shape the work we do.

Around 40 invited guests, including members from Friends of Thamesmead Parks, our Resident Auditors, Asset Management Focus Group and Tavy Bridge Regeneration Residents Action Group, enjoyed afternoon tea and light entertainment.

We are keen to continue to encourage residents to get as involved as possible in everything we do. This is an exciting time for us. We have so many projects underway and ambitious plans for the future but they will not be as successful as they could be without your involvement. So please get in touch; call our switchboard on 0300 123 1237.


Residents enjoying the event

THINGS TO DO

THE SCIENCE MUSEUM

Over seven floors of educational and entertaining exhibits for all ages, including the Apollo 10 command module and a flight simulator. There are so many things to see and do at this venue; well worth visiting.

Where Exhibition Rd, London SW7 2DD

Cost Free

Transport Nearest tube: South Kensington

More information
www.sciencemuseum.org.uk
0870 870 4868

GREENWICH HERITAGE CENTRE
INSIDE THE ARSENAL EXHIBITION

A free exhibition that tells the story of the Royal Arsenal and the Royal Woolwich Dockyard across 400 years of history from Henry VIII to modern times.

Where Artillery Square, Royal Arsenal, Woolwich SE18 4DX

Transport Buses: 51, 96, 99, 122, 161, 177, 180, 244, 380, 422, 469, 472
DLR: Woolwich Arsenal

More information
heritage.centre@royalgreenwich.gov.uk
020 8854 2452

CUTTY SARK CLIPPER SHIP

The Cutty Sark reopened in April last year after the original ship was badly damaged by fire. You have the chance, once again, to view this extraordinary ship – the last surviving tea clipper, the fastest and greatest of her time.

Where King William Walk, Greenwich, London SE10 9HT

Cost Not cheap; children under five and members go free but family tickets start at £20 (for one adult and two children) rising to £29 (two adults and two children).

HOW ARE WE PERFORMING?

APRIL – OCTOBER 2013

Complaints – we received 52 complaints in this period. We monitor them and try to learn from our mistakes.	**Targets**	**Actual**	
Complaints responded to within timescale	90%	97.17%	
% of residents satisfied with the complaints process	75%	83.94%	
Contacting us			
Calls answered within 20 seconds	80%	94.49%	
Repairs			
Appointments kept as % of appointments made	99%	99.84%	
% of repairs completed right first time	93%	92.47%	
Average number of days to re-let a home	24 Days	26 Days	
Rent			
Rent collected as % of rent owed	99.5%	100.13%	
Team Gallions			
Abandoned & untaxed cars reported to us		28	
Abandoned & untaxed cars reported to local authority		28	
Amount of normal waste removed	490 Tonnes	422.22* Tonnes	

 Performance is at or above target

 Performance is slightly below target

 Performance is significantly below target

*A lower figure means less rubbish on our estates – which is good news. It shows that our initiatives to reduce waste, such as more enforcement action and a push towards recycling, are working.

How to complain or give a compliment

There are lots of ways for you to comment on the services.

By telephone: 0300 123 1237
Through the website: www.gallionsha.co.uk
Email: Complaints@gallionsha.co.uk
In writing: to PO Box 268, Sidcup, DA15 0FB

WIN WITH OUR WORD SEARCH

IN THIS WORDSEARCH WE HAVE HIDDEN THE NAMES OF SIX TYPES OF TEAS. FIND THEM ALL AND YOU COULD WIN A £30 SHOPPING VOUCHER.

Green
Assam
Rooibos
Yunnan
Nilgiri
Black

M	A	E	B	F	B	G	D	B	B	I	F	R
E	U	H	G	I	G	J	N	L	G	L	C	O
W	A	N	R	F	B	G	D	A	B	I	F	O
Y	Y	U	E	V	E	X	B	C	E	Z	V	I
U	B	A	E	R	C	I	E	K	C	T	I	B
N	A	E	N	F	B	G	D	B	B	I	F	O
N	N	C	A	R	A	V	A	A	A	Z	S	S
A	C	U	W	V	W	X	O	W	W	Z	Q	Z
N	A	E	B	F	B	G	D	B	B	I	F	E
R	K	Q	N	A	S	S	A	M	N	M	R	L
W	A	E	B	F	B	G	D	B	B	I	F	E
E	Y	D	Z	C	Z	B	B	Z	Z	Z	D	Y
W	N	I	L	G	I	R	I	B	B	I	F	E

DID YOU KNOW...

Tea was introduced to England in mid 17th century. So popular was tea drinking, the government tried to profit from the trade by taxing suppliers heavily. By the mid 18th century duty on tea had reached 119%; but to trace the history of tea drinking you have to go back to the third millennium BC in China where it all began.

Please return your completed wordsearch and details to: Communications Team, Gallions Housing Association, Freepost RSLT-LYEG-HZAL, PO Box 268, Sidcup, DA15 0FB or drop it into our reception by 17 January 2014. The winner will be selected at random.

Name:

Address:

Telephone:

Email:

WELL DONE...
to Bernadette Kavanagh who was the winner of our last wordsearch competition.

Kidsview WORDSEARCH

IN THIS WORDSEARCH WE HAVE HIDDEN THE NAMES OF SIX CHARACTERS FROM THE WINNIE-THE-POOH SERIES OF BOOKS. IF YOU ARE LUCKY ENOUGH TO FIND ALL SIX YOU COULD WIN THE COLLECTION.

J	L	O	U	P	I	G	L	E	T	N	I	O
J	J	O	U	E	I	O	O	M	J	O	I	O
B	I	Q	M	C	L	Q	Q	D	J	R	H	Q
K	K	A	V	F	J	A	A	C	K	A	Z	T
A	P	O	U	E	I	O	O	M	J	B	I	I
N	L	O	X	I	K	O	O	K	L	B	U	G
G	S	S	O	E	P	S	S	F	R	I	S	G
A	Z	Z	Y	V	L	Z	Z	Y	M	T	M	E
C	T	T	C	F	D	T	T	G	F	G	G	R
C	N	E	Z	E	A	N	N	P	A	V	Z	N
H	U	G	T	G	O	U	U	H	L	U	X	U
H	U	U	T	G	E	E	Y	O	R	E	D	U
J	O	O	U	E	I	O	O	M	J	O	W	L

KANGA

PIGLET

RABBIT

TIGGER

OWL

EEYORE

This competition is just for kids under 12. Please return your completed wordsearch and details to: Communications Team, Gallions Housing Association, Freepost RSLT-LYEG-HZAL, PO Box 268, Sidcup, DA15 0FB or drop it into our reception by 17 January 2014. The winner will be selected at random.

GALLIONS

Child's name:

Parent's name:

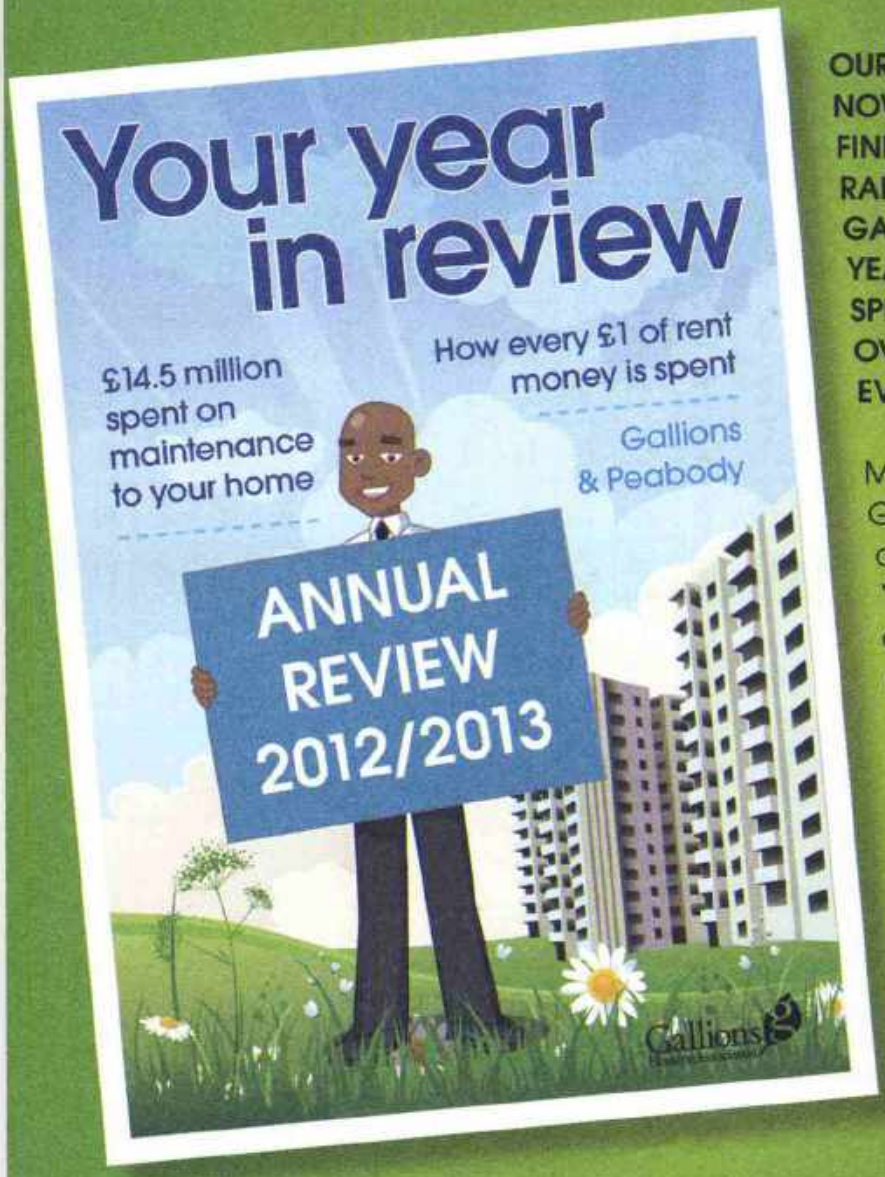
Address:

Telephone:

WELL DONE...

to Billie Leman who was the winner of our last wordsearch competition

WHAT WE HAVE BEEN UP TO;
2012-2013 ANNUAL REPORT PUBLISHED



OUR LATEST ANNUAL REPORT IS NOW PUBLISHED! YOU CAN FIND USEFUL INFORMATION RANGING FROM HOW GALLIONS PERFORMED THIS YEAR, WHERE RENT MONEY IS SPENT AND LOOKING BACK OVER THE PAST YEARS' EVENTS AND ACTIVITIES.

Managing Director of Gallions has this to say about the report:
"I encourage you to look at the annual report and read about all of the projects and milestones we have accomplished this year. The annual report is a great way for residents to find out what we've been up to."

You can find the annual report on our website: www.gallionsha.co.uk under corporate information/ corporate publications

Or you can request a hard copy by email or phone e:communications@gallionsha.co.uk t:0300 123 1237